progress in literature, art and architecture. Similarly the Ottoman Turks who moved Anatolia (Asia Minor) and established an independent empire contributed to science and technology in a big way.

## EAST ASIA IN THE MIDDLE AGES

## 6.1 China: Tang Dynasty (618–907 A.D. (C.E.))

Sui dynasty collapsed in forty years because of financial burden imposed by public works like the Grand Canal and the expensive wars waged to conquer northern part of Korea. The T'ang dynasty rose from the widespread rebellions that took place to establish a strong centralised empire. Li Yuan who organised the rebellion made Yang You the emperor of China. As Yang you was killed by one of his royal officials, the Chancellor, Li Yuan proclaimed himself emperor. Several hundred kilometres of the Great Wall were rebuilt along the north-west frontiers. Military campaigns extended the empire's influence into Korea in the east and as far as the borders of Persia and Indo-China in the west.



**Great Wall of China:** Between 8th and 7th centuries B.C. (BCE), the warring states in China built defensive walls to protect themselves from enemies from the north. During Chin (Qin) Dynasty, the separate walls were connected and consequently the wall stretched from east to west for about 5000 kilometres. This wall, considered to be one of the wonders of the world, served to keep nomadic tribes out. The Wall was further extended and strengthened by the succeeding dynasties. Now it is 6,700 kilometres in length.

Tang dynasty undertook enormous public works. Two capital cities, Boyang and Chang-on, were built. Scholar officials, trained in Confucius Philosophy, were appointed to counterbalance the landowning aristocratic class. Land was divided into small peasant holdings. As a result, the agricultural surplus went to the state as taxes, not to the aristocrats as rents. State monopoly of salt, and tea added to its revenues.

### Sung Dynasty (960–1279 A.D. (C.E.))

The rebellion of hard-pressed peasantry under the leadership of Hung Ch'ao dealt a death knell to the tottering Tang empire. The empire split into five rival states, until it was reunited under a new dynasty, Sung. Trade and industry flourished during the reign of Sung dynasty. Iron and steel industries became highly organized.



The quantity of iron China produced in 1078 A.D. (C.E.) exceeded 114,000 tons (England produced only 68,000 tons even in 1788). China excelled in ceramics and porcelain-making. This technique was not known to Europe for another 700 years. Gun powder was in use by 1044. China possessed printed books half a millennium before Europe. (Chris Harman, *A People's History of the World,* p. 111.)

### Fall of Sung Dynasty

Sung period was also a period of great prosperity to the landowning class, officials and rich merchants. The peasants, by contrast, had to suffer grinding poverty. Before any internal crisis could develop, there were two external invasions from the north that ended the Sung dynasty. The



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